

In-Game Adjustments, Tempo, and the Sideline Battle

What coaches actually change between series and at halftime, why some offenses sprint to the line, how defenses answer, and whether the ‘halftime adjustments’ story survives the data

Second quarter, first-and-10. The offense hits a 20-yard pass, and before the defense’s linebackers have turned around, the quarterback is already standing behind the center, eight seconds after the tackle, waving his receivers into place. On the defensive sideline you can see the coordinator frantically waving a fresh defensive back *off*: too late to swap him in. The defense plays the next snap with the players who were too tired to cover the last one. Twenty minutes later, coming out of the locker room, the analyst says it: “This game will be decided by who makes the better halftime adjustments.” What actually happens in those two moments? Who decides what, with what information, and in how much time? And is the halftime story even true?

You’ll be able to:

- Describe what a staff can change between series and at halftime, who sees what (the booth, the sideline, the tablets), and why most adjustments are re-rankings and rule tweaks rather than new plays.
- Tell tempo, the hurry-up and the no-huddle apart, and explain the substitution-matching rule and how a fast offense uses it to freeze a defense in the wrong personnel.
- Explain the sugar huddle and spot it on a broadcast.
- Name the defense’s answers to tempo (simplified calls, rule-based checks, versatile personnel) and what each costs.
- Follow a coordinator-versus-coordinator sequence, the “call after the call,” across a game.
- Judge a “halftime adjustments” claim against second-half data: regression to the mean, score effects and possessions.

i You’ll need

- **The Game Plan: A Week Inside an NFL Building:** the game plan, the opening script and the situational call sheet, the week’s menu that every in-game adjustment chooses from. In one line: by Sunday the staff has cut the playbook to a few dozen plays, sorted by situation, and practiced them; this chapter is about re-sorting that menu in real time.
- Helpful too: the play-caller, the no-huddle, the 15-second radio cut-off and the staff map from What a Play Really Is; substitution matching from Personnel Groupings; the check-with-me from The Pre-Snap Phase; tendencies and sequencing from Constraint Theory; and EPA and success rate from Downs, Distance, and Field Position.

How to read the diagrams. Offense is blue circles, defense orange squares, and *left* and *right* are always the offense’s. Q is the quarterback, R the running back, Y and U the tight ends, X and Z the wide receivers and H a slot receiver; C is the center (the other linemen are unlabelled). On defense, E and T are the ends and tackles, S, M and W the Sam, Mike and Will linebackers, \$ the nickel back, CB the cornerbacks and FS and SS the safeties. Solid arrows are routes and rushes, dashed arrows zone drops (with a shaded zone), dotted lines man coverage, a dashed brown arrow a throw. A **red ring** marks the defender a play is built to punish, a **purple ring** a player to watch. The frame strips are simulated plays in Big Data Bowl format, not real tracking.

The game is re-planned every series

Start with a fact that surprises most fans: once the game starts, nobody installs anything. The plays a team will run on Sunday were chosen, taught and practiced from Wednesday to Friday (The Game Plan walks through that week). What changes during a game is the *order* of the menu, the *rules* players use inside each play, and the play-caller’s beliefs about what the opponent is doing. That is still a lot. It’s the difference between a chef inventing a dish mid-service, which never happens, and a chef noticing that table six hates cilantro, which happens all night.

Two kinds of information drive those changes, and they arrive in two places.

From above. The **coaching booth** is the glassed-in coaches’ room at press-box level, the place you met in What a Play Really Is. From up there you see all 22 players at once, including the safeties 15 yards deep whom nobody on the sideline can see. Typically one coordinator, or an assistant who isn’t calling plays, sits there with the quality control coaches and analysts. While the game goes on they keep running tallies: what coverage did the defense play against each personnel group, did the safety rotate toward

the motion, which blitzes came on third down, which of our linemen is losing. The league even provides a booth dashboard for counting personnel groupings and play results in real time.¹ It is a coach with a spreadsheet and a headset, not a genius with a flash of insight.

From the sideline. Since the 2014 season every team has had league-issued Microsoft Surface tablets on the sideline and in the booth. On them, within seconds of each snap, coaches and players get high-resolution still photos of the formation before the snap and the shape of the play just after it.² Under the league's equity rule each team may use only as many working tablets as its opponent has, so a failure on one side shuts down the same number on the other.³ The pictures are stills, not video; the point is to answer a specific question ("where was the safety when you released?") with a picture instead of an argument.

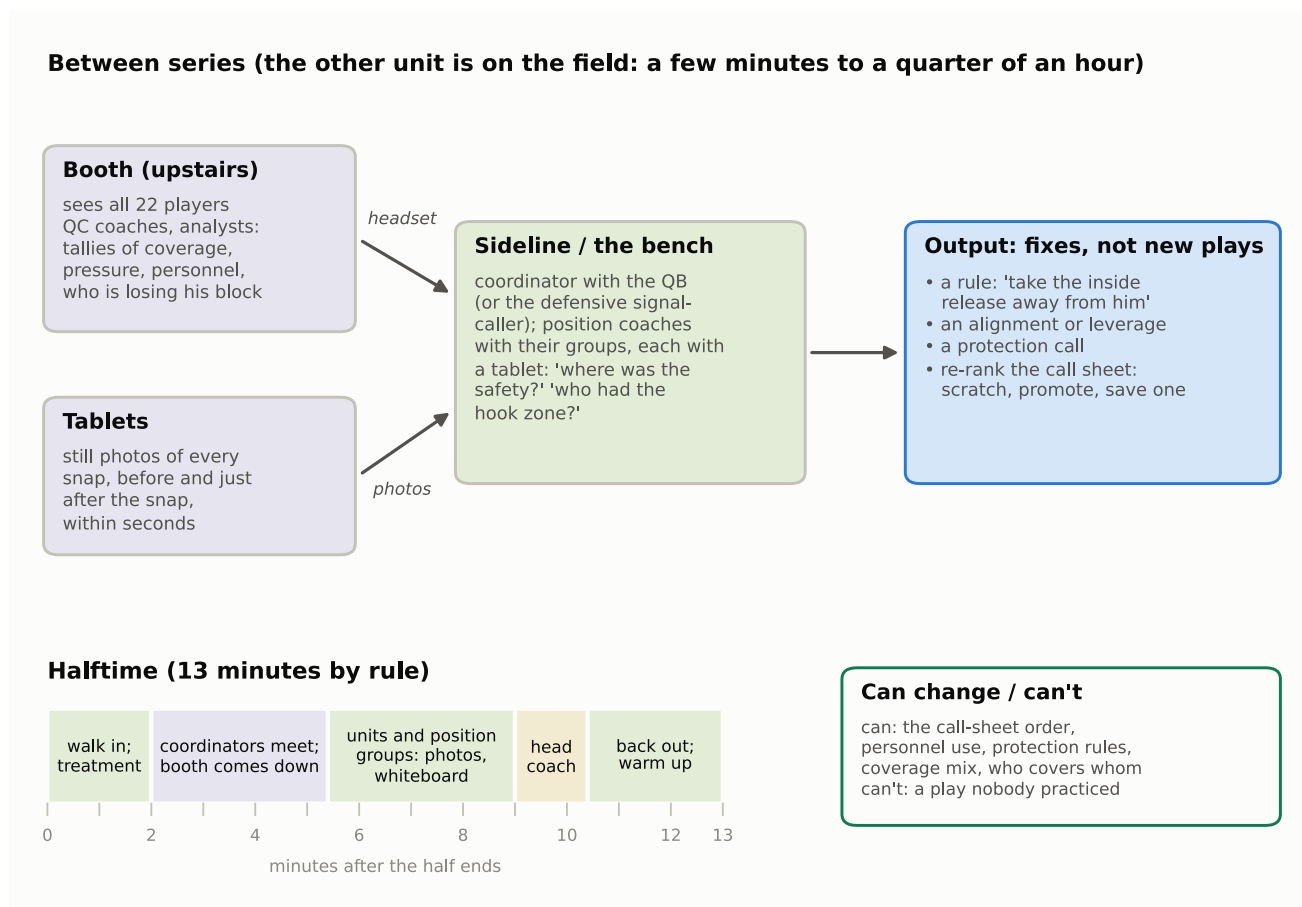


Figure 1: Two windows for adjusting a game plan (illustrative; staffs differ). Top: between series, while the other unit is on the field, the booth's tallies and the tablet photos meet the coaches and players on the bench, and the output is small: a rule, an alignment, a protection call, a re-ranked call sheet. Bottom: the 13-minute halftime, roughly how a staff spends it. The bars are a typical order, not a timetable, and the right-hand box is the honest list of what can change.

The loop in Figure 1 runs every time the offense or defense comes off the field. A typical exchange takes a few minutes and sounds mundane. The booth says the corner is playing inside leverage on the slot every time it sees trips; the receivers coach shows the slot receiver the photo and tells him to take the outside release; the coordinator moves a play that attacks outside leverage up his

¹NFL Football Operations, "Sideline Technology," which describes the league-provided "analytics device" in the coaches' booth (since 2025 a Copilot-powered Excel dashboard) that "supports real-time evaluation of offensive and defensive personnel groupings, snap counts, play results, yards gained, and lineup tendencies": <https://operations.nfl.com/the-game/technology/sideline-of-the-future/>. What each staff puts in its booth, and who sits there, varies by team.

²NFL Football Operations, "Sideline Technology": "Starting in the 2014 season, all teams have sideline access to league-provided, specially configured Microsoft Surface tablets, on which they receive high-resolution color images almost instantaneously": <https://operations.nfl.com/the-game/technology/sideline-of-the-future/>. The league tested video on the tablets in the 2015 preseason; regular-season use has been limited to still images. See NFL.com, "Surface tablets might have found permanent home on NFL sideline": <https://www.nfl.com/news/surface-tablets-might-have-found-permanent-home-on-nfl-sideline-0ap3000000430360>. Proposals to add video were made but not adopted; when college football first allowed in-game video on its sideline tablets in 2024, the NFL still allowed only still images (Sportico, Aug. 2024: <https://www.sportico.com/leagues/college-sports/2024/college-football-sideline-tablet-video-rules-2024-1234793971>), and the league's own page, updated for the 2025 switch to Surface Copilot+ PCs, still describes images only.

³NFL Football Operations, "NFL Equity Rule," which limits each club to as many working sideline and booth viewing devices as its opponent has: <https://operations.nfl.com/gameday/behind-the-scenes/nfl-equity-rule>.

list for the next series. On defense: the booth notices the offense has run the same crossing concept against man coverage three times, so the coordinator reminds two defenders of the switch rule they practiced for it on Thursday.

! Why it exists: the booth and the tablets

Every play has two halves of information: what the defense *showed* before the snap and what it *did* after. Players see their own patch of grass; the sideline sees helmets. The booth and the tablets exist to give the people making the next decision the whole picture, fast. The cost is attention and trust. A coordinator who tries to absorb everything the booth sees stops thinking about the next call, so good staffs filter hard: the booth reports only what the play-caller has asked it to look for, plus anything that has changed. Which coordinator sits upstairs varies by team, which you can usually spot on a broadcast by who is shown wearing a headset in the press box.

i Madden vs. real life

In a video game, when a play stops working you scroll to a different one: the whole playbook is always available. A real team can only run what it practiced that week, and a play that hasn't been repped against the opponent's looks is a play somebody will run wrong. So "adjusting" in the NFL mostly means choosing differently from a small menu, and changing small rules inside plays (a protection that slides the other way, a corner who stops pressing a fast receiver), not drawing up something new in the dirt. Coaches do occasionally scribble a wrinkle on a whiteboard, but the bigger the change, the more likely it is to be run badly.

Halftime: thirteen minutes

The NFL's halftime is 13 minutes by rule.⁴ For the staff, that is the one sustained block of the game in which every coach and player is in the same room, and the coaches from the booth come down to join them. A **halftime adjustment** is a change to the game plan made in that window.

Thirteen minutes is less than it sounds. Players need to walk in, get treatment and use the bathroom; they have to be back on the field in time to warm up; and the head coach usually wants a minute with the whole team. What's left is a few minutes for coordinators to agree on what they've seen and a few minutes for each unit to hear the changes. That shapes what a halftime adjustment can be:

- **Re-ranking the sheet.** The plays that worked move up, the ones that didn't get scratched, and the constraint plays that the first half set up (Constraint Theory) get scheduled. This is the commonest and cheapest change.
- **Changing who does what inside the plays already installed.** Sliding the protection toward a rusher who is winning, keeping a tight end in to help a struggling tackle, moving the best corner onto the receiver who is hurting you, playing more of the coverage that held up and less of the one that didn't.
- **Changing the mix.** More of one personnel group, more motion, more runs, fewer blitzes. The plays are the same; their frequencies change.
- **Fixing a tell.** If the opponent seems to know what's coming, a staff looks for what's giving it away (a back's alignment, a linebacker's stance) and changes it.

What halftime rarely produces is something new. A new play would need everyone to learn their part, every lineman to know his assignment against every front, and the quarterback to know his reads, all in five minutes and without a single rep.

🔥 Common misconception

"The second half was won in the locker room." Sometimes the halftime change is real and visible: a team that was blitzed to pieces comes out keeping six in to protect, or a defense that was gashed by outside runs starts setting the edge differently. But a lot of what gets called a halftime adjustment is the scoreboard, the clock and plain luck moving in the other direction, as the last part of this chapter shows with data. When you hear the phrase, ask: what *specifically* changed?

⁴NFL Rulebook (2026), Rule 4, Section 1, Article 3: "Between the second and third periods, there shall be an intermission of 13 minutes": <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. Super Bowl halftimes run longer for the show.

Tempo: the clock between plays

Now the other weapon a staff can use during a game: speed. When a play ends, the 40-second play clock starts, and the offense must snap the ball before it reaches zero.⁵ What it does with those 40 seconds is its **tempo**: how fast it gets to the line and snaps. Most offenses, most of the time, use almost all of it: huddle, line up, shift or motion, look at the defense, snap with a few seconds left. A **hurry-up offense** does the opposite and snaps as fast as it can. Every team hurries when it's short of time (the two-minute drill, the subject of The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down). The interesting question is the team that hurries when it *doesn't* have to.

Three words get mixed up on broadcasts, so pin them down:

- **No-huddle** is about *communication*: the call reaches the players at the line, by signals, words or wristbands, instead of in a huddle (What a Play Really Is).
- **Tempo** is about *speed*: how much of the play clock the offense uses.
- **Hurry-up** is tempo turned all the way up.

A team can go no-huddle and still be slow (line up fast, then look at the defense and wait for the sideline), and a team can huddle and still be fast, as you'll see with the sugar huddle below.

How fast do NFL offenses actually play? The play-by-play data doesn't record the play clock reliably, but it does record the game clock at every snap. On snaps where the clock kept running between plays (the earlier play was a run or a completed pass that stayed in bounds, with no penalty or timeout), the game-clock seconds between two snaps measure how long the play took plus how long the offense took to snap the next one.⁶ A team that snaps with the play clock nearly expired lands around 40 seconds or a bit more; a true hurry-up offense lands around 25 to 30.

⁵NFL Rulebook (2026), Rule 4, Section 6, Article 1 (the 40-second play clock, which starts when a play ends) and Article 2 (a 25-second clock after certain administrative stoppages): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>.

⁶Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play (`game_seconds_remaining`), regular seasons. A pair of snaps counts when both are runs or passes on the same drive and quarter, nothing else is logged between them, the earlier play was a run or a completed pass that did not go out of bounds and had no penalty, timeout, touchdown, lost fumble or spike, both snaps came with win probability between 20% and 80%, and the earlier snap came with more than 2:30 left in the half (so the two-minute warning and the late-half out-of-bounds clock rules can't interfere). Gaps under 5 or over 60 seconds are dropped as clock errors. The number includes the duration of the earlier play (usually 4–7 seconds), so it is not the same as time left on the play clock; nflverse's `play_clock` field is not usable for this. The 30-second threshold is this chapter's choice.

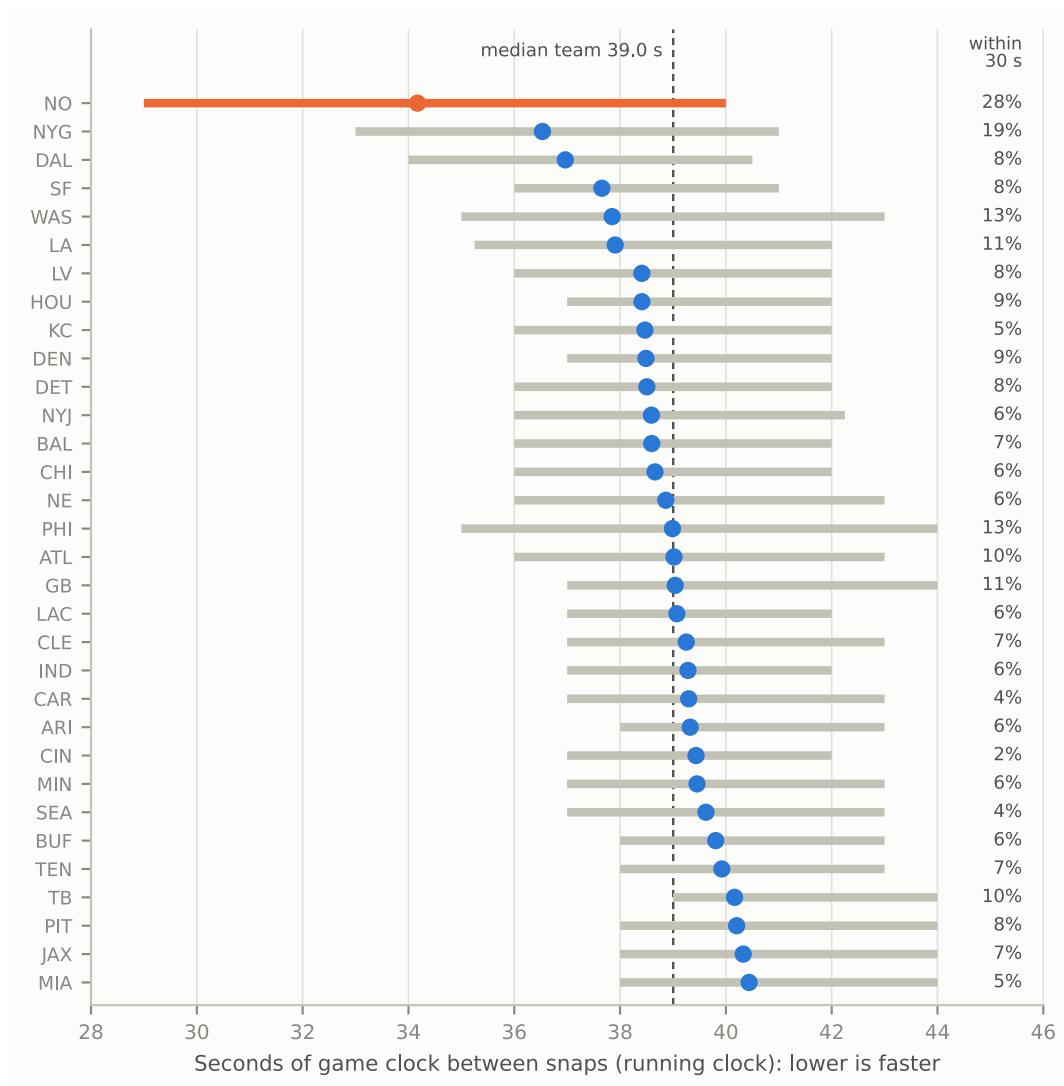


Figure 2: Tempo by team, 2025 regular season: game-clock seconds from one snap to the next when the clock kept running between them, in neutral game states (win probability 20–80%) and outside the last 2:30 of each half. Dots are each team’s average and bars span its middle half of snaps; the number on the right is the share of those snaps that came within 30 seconds. Lower is faster. The league is bunched between about 36 and 40 seconds; New Orleans (orange) was the one offense that regularly pushed the pace.

Source: nflverse play-by-play.

Figure 2 says something worth absorbing before any history: the modern NFL barely hurries in normal game situations. The median team averaged about 39 seconds between running-clock snaps, which means it snapped near the end of the play clock, and only one team, Kellen Moore’s New Orleans Saints,⁷ averaged under 35. No-huddle snaps were faster (a median of 31 seconds against 40), but not all no-huddle teams are fast: Washington skipped the huddle on about 78% of these snaps and still had a median of 39 seconds, the “information” no-huddle you met in What a Play Really Is.

Why go fast?

If almost nobody does it, why does tempo matter? Because when a team turns it on, at the right moment, it attacks the defense in four ways.

1. **Fatigue.** Defensive linemen are the biggest men on the field and the ones doing the most violent work. A 300-pound tackle who has just chased a play 20 yards downfield gets maybe 15 seconds to breathe instead of 30 or more. Tired linemen stop winning their blocks and tired defensive backs stop running with receivers.

⁷The Saints hired Moore, the Eagles’ offensive coordinator, as head coach on Feb. 11, 2025 (ESPN: https://africa.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/43630181/new-orleans-saints-hiring-kellen-moore-philadelphia-eagles-super-bowl-2025).

2. **The substitution freeze.** The rules let the defense match the offense's personnel only when the offense substitutes. If the offense keeps the same eleven and lines up quickly, the defense is stuck with whoever is on the field. This is big enough to get its own section, next.
3. **Simplifying the defense.** Disguise, pressure and rotation take time: the call has to be signalled in, relayed, and then the defenders have to walk to their spots and hold a fake picture. Snap fast and the defense has to line up where it will play, which means the quarterback sees the truth.
4. **More snaps.** More plays per game means more chances for a better offense's edge to show up, the same logic as a better poker player wanting to play more hands.

And the costs, because there are always costs:

- **Your own substitutions get harder.** Changing your own personnel invites the defense to change too and slows you down, so a tempo offense tends to stay in one or two groups and needs players who can do several jobs: a tight end who can block *and* run routes.
- **Your own players get tired** too, and so do the call and the communication: a tempo offense needs short calls, simple rules and a quarterback who can manage the line.
- **The other team gets the ball back sooner.** A fast three-and-out leaves your own defense on the field after barely sitting down. That last cost turns out to be big, as the Eagles film room below shows.

The substitution freeze

Here is the rule that makes tempo a strategic weapon rather than just exercise. Before the two-minute warning of each half, if the offense substitutes, it may not snap the ball until the defense has had a chance to respond with its own substitutions. In practice the umpire stands over the ball, and the referee signals when the defense has had a reasonable time. An offense that substitutes and then rushes to the line to catch the defense with too many players is warned the first time and penalized for unsportsmanlike conduct after that.⁸ That is substitution matching, the rule you met in Personnel Groupings, seen from the clock's point of view.

Read it backwards and you have the tempo offense's loophole. The protection exists *only when the offense substitutes*. If the offense sends out the same eleven players, there is no umpire standing over the ball, and the offense may snap as soon as it is set. The defense can still change players, but at its own risk: if the offense snaps while a twelfth defender is still on the field, that is a five-yard penalty, and if he's still running off at the snap, the play goes on and the offense can keep the result or take the yards. That is the **substitution freeze**: by keeping its personnel and moving fast, the offense freezes the defense in whatever personnel it had on the field.

⁸NFL Rulebook (2026), Rule 5, Section 2, Article 10 ("If a substitution is made by the offense before the two-minute warning of either half, the offense shall not be permitted to snap the ball until the defense has been permitted to respond with its substitutions"; "The Umpire will stand over the ball until the Referee deems that the defense has had a reasonable time to complete its substitutions"; a first violation brings a warning and a replay of the down, later ones a 15-yard unsportsmanlike conduct foul) and Article 11 (simulated substitutions): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. On too many men, Rule 5, Section 1, and What a Play Really Is.

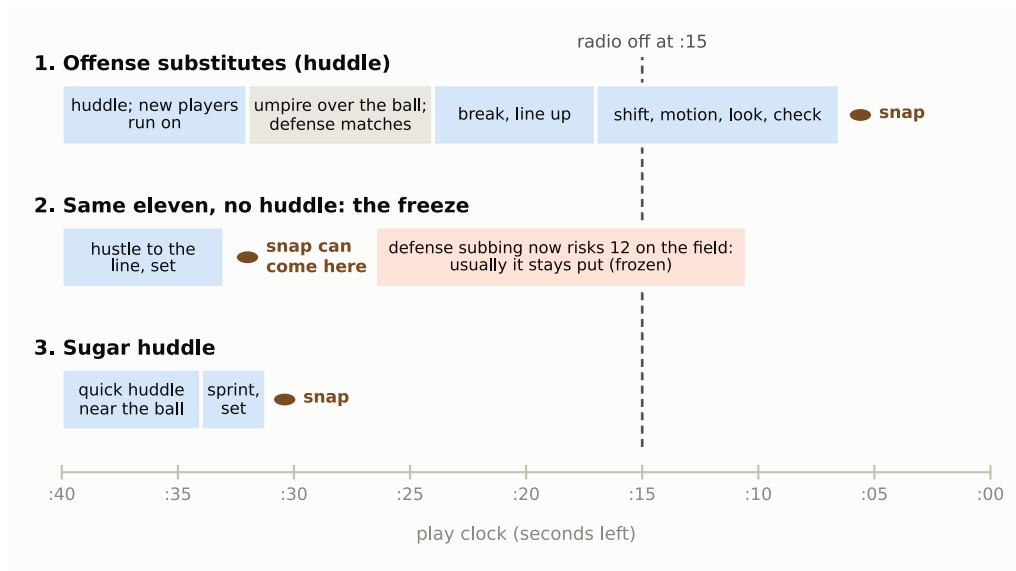


Figure 3: The substitution-matching rule along the 40-second play clock (illustrative timings). Top: when the offense substitutes, the umpire stands over the ball until the defense has had time to match, so the snap can't come early. Middle: with the same eleven players and no huddle, nothing holds the snap back; the offense can snap as soon as it is set, and a defense that changes players does so at the risk of a penalty for too many men. Bottom: the sugar huddle, a quick huddle near the ball, then a sprint and an early snap. The dashed line is the 15-second cut-off for the coach-to-player radio. Inside the last two minutes of each half the umpire does not hold the ball for the defense.

Figure 3 also shows why matching matters so much to a defense in the first place. Modern defenses are built in packages: base personnel with three linebackers against heavy offenses, nickel and dime with extra defensive backs against three and four receivers (A First Look at Defense). Each package is right against some offensive groups and wrong against others. A tempo offense wants to pick the wrong one for the defense and then keep it on the field.

The classic version is in Figure 4. The offense runs a play with two tight ends attached to the line, a run look, and the defense matched with base personnel. Then, with the same eleven players, the offense hurries to the line in a spread formation, both tight ends split out like slot receivers. The defense can't safely bring in its nickel back, so its base linebackers have to deal with a spread formation they weren't chosen for.

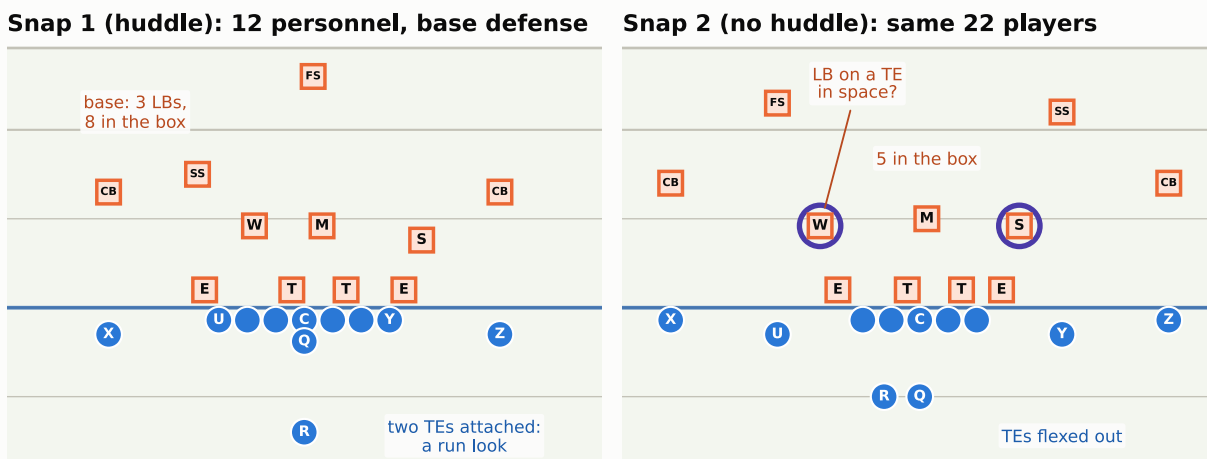


Figure 4: The substitution freeze. Left: on the previous snap the offense was in 12 personnel with both tight ends (Y, U) attached to the line, a run look, and the defense matched with base personnel (three linebackers, eight in the box). Right: the same 22 players a few seconds later. The offense kept its eleven and hurried to the line in a spread formation with both tight ends flexed into the slots. The defense can't safely substitute a nickel back, so the outside linebackers (purple rings) split the difference between the box and the tight ends. Now the box has five defenders against five linemen, and each tight end is covered, if at all, by a linebacker in space.

Notice what the freeze does *not* do. It doesn't guarantee a good play: base linebackers can cover tight ends, and many defenses have a call ready for exactly this. What it does is take away the defense's best tool, choosing the right players, and force the defense to solve the problem with alignment and rules, which is harder and more error-prone. And the offense gets to choose its moment: tempo is usually a change-up, turned on after a big gain (when the defense is tired and wants to substitute), or when the offense sees a personnel group it likes on the field.

! Why it exists: the matching rule

Why does the rulebook protect the defense at all? Because without it, a substitution would be a weapon in itself: the offense could change players and snap before the defense even knew what was on the field. The rule's bargain is that the offense gets to choose first (it substitutes, the defense reacts) but has to give the defense a fair moment to react. The freeze is the price the offense pays in reverse: give up your own right to substitute, and you take away the defense's protection. It's a trade-off built into the rules, and the defense has its own lever too. Since 2025 officials have been told to close the substitution window if a defense deliberately slow-walks its substitutes, and an offense that fakes a substitution (a player jogging onto the field and back off to draw a defensive response) now opens a substitution window, with a warning first and a 15-yard penalty after that. The trigger was a Packers fake substitution in Week 3 of the 2025 season.⁹

The sugar huddle

Between the huddle and the no-huddle sits a hybrid. In a **sugar huddle** the offense huddles quickly, a few yards from the ball instead of the usual seven or eight, breaks almost at once, sprints to the line and snaps fast. It gets the huddle's strengths (everyone hears the whole call in one voice, the defense can't read signals) without giving the defense its usual time to substitute, signal its call and set a disguise. It is especially useful for one specific call: a fourth-and-short or a big third down where the offense has a play it loves and wants to run before the defense can bring in its short-yardage package or call a timeout. Ben Johnson's Lions were known for it at key moments, and Chicago expected him to bring it with him when he became the Bears' head coach in 2025.¹⁰

You can spot one easily once you know to look: the huddle forms *very* close to the ball, sometimes with the quarterback facing the line, and the players are in their stances a second or two after it breaks. On the defensive side, watch for defenders looking to the sideline for a call that hasn't arrived.

A short history of going fast

Tempo has a richer history than most schemes, because every time an offense used it, the league and the defenses argued about whether it was fair.

Cincinnati, 1988. The first NFL team to make the no-huddle a standard weapon was Sam Wyche's Bengals, who called it their "attack offense": shortened huddles very close to the line, or none at all. In the 1988 playoffs the Seahawks answered it with a transparent tactic: their defensive tackle Joe Nash went down with an "injury" on third down after third down, which stopped the clock and let Seattle bring in its nickel package. Before the AFC Championship Game against Buffalo, Bills coach Marv Levy said he'd do the same, and the league decided to step in. About two hours before kickoff, a league representative told Wyche that the Bengals would be penalized 15 yards for unsportsmanlike conduct every time they ran the no-huddle. Wyche, a former NFL quarterback with a gambler's nerve and a showman's streak, demanded the commissioner on the phone and threatened to tell the world after the game that the Bengals had lost because of the league's penalties. The ruling was reversed within seconds. Cincinnati won 21–10, mostly by running the ball 50 times.¹¹

⁹Football Zebras, "NFL officials instructed on new procedures for substitution tactics" (Oct. 2, 2025): defenses that substitute "at less than normal speed" have the window closed; a simulated substitution opens a substitution period, with a warning and then a 15-yard unsportsmanlike conduct foul if the offense snaps during it; field goals and the last two minutes are exempt; prompted by a Green Bay simulated substitution in Week 3: <https://www.footballzebras.com/2025/10/nfl-officials-instructed-on-new-procedures-for-substitution-tactics/>.

¹⁰Kirsten Tanis, "One big change coming to the Chicago Bears' new offense," *Sports Illustrated* Bear Digest (July 10, 2025), on Johnson's use of "sugar huddles, where the normal huddle takes place but then is broken rapidly and the play quickly executed": <https://www.si.com/nfl/bears/onsi/news/one-big-change-coming-to-the-chicago-bears-new-offense-nfl>; Pride of Detroit, film breakdown of the Lions' fourth-down attempts against Green Bay (Dec. 10, 2024): <https://www.prideofdetroit.com/2024/12/10/24317435/detroit-lions-film-breakdown-all-22-green-bay-packers-fourth-down-attempts-thursday-night-football>.

¹¹Geoff Hobson, "The Day the Bengals Made History and the Future," *Bengals.com* (Jan. 18, 2019), on Joe Nash's injuries in the divisional round, Levy's threat, the league's plan to penalize the no-huddle, Wyche's response and the 21–10 win with 50 rushing attempts: <https://www.bengals.com/news/the-day-the-bengals-made-history-and-the-future>. The game was played on Jan. 8, 1989. Wyche's own retellings differ in the details (how long the reversal took, what he said); see also "Ten questions with Sam Wyche," *Fox Sports*: <https://www.foxsports.com/stories/nfl/ten-questions-with-sam-wyche>. Wikipedia's "Hurry-up offense" article credits the 1988 Bengals as the first NFL team to use the no-huddle as a standard strategy: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hurry-up_offense.

Buffalo, 1990. The team that lost that game learned from it. The Bills built their own version, the *K-Gun*, a no-huddle offense built around three wide receivers and a tight end who could block and catch (Keith McKeller, whose nickname “Killer” gave the offense its K, by most accounts) and quarterback Jim Kelly calling the plays at the line.¹² Under head coach Marv Levy and offensive coordinator Ted Marchibroda, Buffalo went 13–3 in 1990, led the league with 428 points, beat the Raiders 51–3 in the AFC Championship Game, and went on to play in four straight Super Bowls.¹³ The K-Gun was tempo as a *system*: the same personnel all game, the defense frozen in whatever personnel it started the drive with, the quarterback choosing the play after seeing the defense.

It also produced one of the most famous answers to tempo, which wasn’t a defensive scheme at all. In Super Bowl XXV, the New York Giants kept the ball for 40 minutes and 33 seconds, a Super Bowl record, by running the ball and sustaining long drives, and won 20–19. The best defense against a fast offense is an offense that keeps it on the bench. (Bill Belichick’s defensive plan for that game, which invited the Bills to run rather than throw, is drawn in The Belichick Patriots.)

Indianapolis and Denver, 2000s–2013. Peyton Manning’s no-huddle was the information version: line up early, read the defense, and change the play at the line while the defense, frozen in its personnel, could only disguise (What a Play Really Is tells his “Omaha” story, and The Pre-Snap Phase his check-with-me system). When Manning wanted to, he could also go fast: his 2012 and 2013 Broncos were among the quickest teams in Figure 5, and the 2013 Broncos scored 606 points, still the NFL record.¹⁴ The 2012 Patriots turned their no-huddle into a true hurry-up and ran 1,191 offensive plays, at the time the second-most in NFL history, behind only New England’s own 1994 team.¹⁵

Philadelphia, 2013. Then came the most famous tempo experiment in NFL history.

¹²On the name: “Keith McKeller,” Wikipedia, which says the K-Gun was named for McKeller’s nickname “Killer” rather than for Jim Kelly: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Keith_McKeller; Wikipedia’s “Hurry-up offense” says the same while noting the name “is commonly thought” to come from Kelly, so the attribution is the usual one rather than settled. On the date usually given for the K-Gun’s debut, the Dec. 2, 1990 home game against the Eagles, when Buffalo opened without huddling: Buffalo Rumbblings, “December 2, 1990: Bills unveil no-huddle offense”: <https://www.buffalorumbblings.com/2010/12/2/1848736/december-2-1990-bills-unveil-no-huddle-offense>. The Bills had used the no-huddle in spots before that, as many teams did late in halves.

¹³“Super Bowl XXV,” Wikipedia (Giants 20, Bills 19, Jan. 27, 1991; New York’s 40:33 time of possession, a Super Bowl record; Buffalo’s 13–3 record and league-leading 428 points in 1990; the 51–3 AFC Championship win over the Raiders): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_XXV. The four straight Super Bowls were XXV–XXVIII (1990–1993 seasons).

¹⁴Pro Football Reference, 2013 Denver Broncos (606 points): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/teams/den/2013.htm>; Jeff Legwold, “The 2013 Broncos scored an NFL-record 606 points ... and have been forgotten,” ESPN (Sept. 27, 2023): https://www.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/38492638/denver-broncos-peyton-manning-nfl-record-606-points-2013-season. In nflverse schedules no team has passed it through 2025 (the closest are the 2018 Chiefs, 565, and the 2024 Lions, 564).

¹⁵Pro Football Reference, 2012 New England Patriots: <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/teams/nwe/2012.htm>; Patriots.com, “Inside the Numbers: Regular Season Recap” (Jan. 2, 2014): “The Patriots own the top three totals in NFL history for most ball control plays from scrimmage with 1,199 in 1994, 1,191 in 2012 and 1,187 in 1995”: <https://www.patriots.com/news/inside-the-numbers-regular-season-recap-194956>. In this course’s tempo measure (the twenty-season chart) the 2012 Patriots were the league’s fastest team.

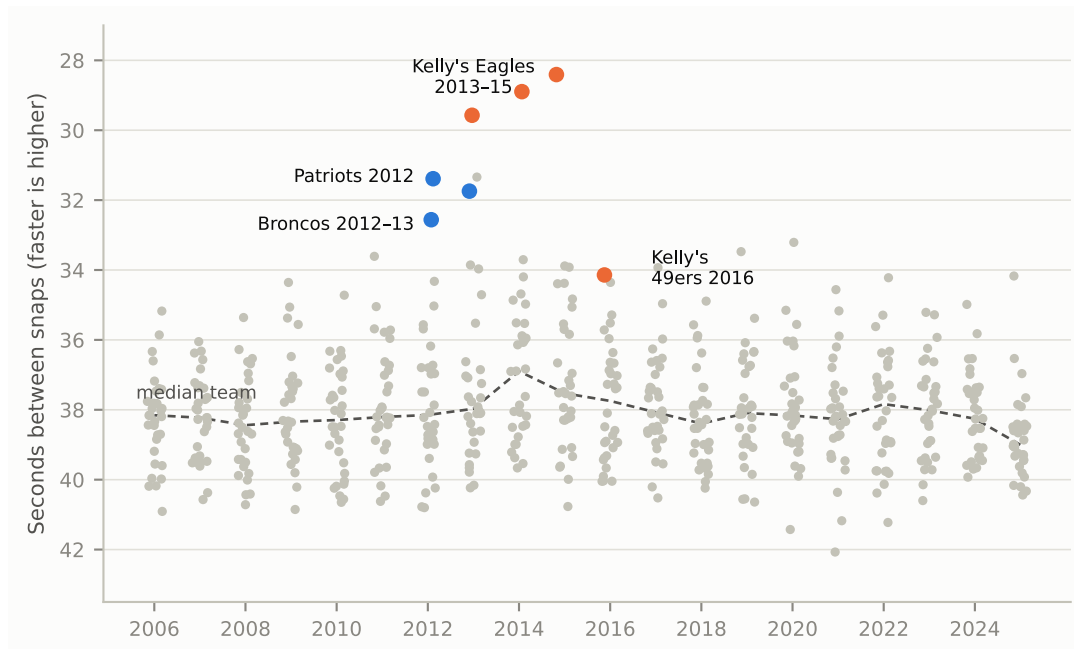


Figure 5: Twenty seasons of tempo. Each dot is one team-season's average game-clock seconds between running-clock snaps in neutral situations (same filters as the previous figure); the axis is flipped, so faster is higher. Chip Kelly's teams (orange: the 2013–2015 Eagles and the 2016 49ers) were the fastest in the league in all four of his seasons, and the 2013–2015 Eagles were faster than any other team-season in these twenty years; the 2012 Patriots and the 2012–2013 Manning Broncos (blue) were the next fastest, just before and alongside him (the 2013 Bills, a grey dot near 31 seconds, matched them). The dashed line is the median team.

Source: nflverse play-by-play, regular seasons 2006–2025.

i Film room: Philadelphia Eagles 2013 (Chip Kelly)

Chip Kelly came to Philadelphia from Oregon, where as head coach from 2009 to 2012 his offense snapped the ball faster than almost anyone in college football, with sideline signal boards and a roster conditioned to play that way.¹⁶ In his first NFL season the Eagles went 10–6, won the NFC East and led the league in rushing.¹⁷ They were also, by a distance, the fastest team in Figure 5: about 29.6 seconds between running-clock snaps, with 59% of those snaps inside 30 seconds, when the median team was near 38. They stayed the fastest team in 2014 and 2015, and Kelly's 2016 49ers were the fastest team that year too.

What to notice: the tempo and the scheme were one idea. The Eagles ran a small number of plays (inside zone and its read-option and bubble-screen packaged plays, the RPOs of RPOs) from a small number of formations, with one personnel group, so they *could* snap fast and so the defense, frozen and tired, had to defend the same plays with the same players over and over. On a good day it looked like the defense was a step slow on everything.

Then notice the bill. Kelly's defense faced more plays than any other defense in the league in all three of his Eagles seasons: 1185 runs and passes in 2013, against a league median of 1058. A fast offense that goes three-and-out sends its own defense back out after a minute of rest. And the league adjusted. The Eagles' offense ranked 4th in EPA per play in 2013, 14th in 2014 and 22nd in 2015.¹⁸ Personnel changed a lot in those years (DeSean Jackson was released after 2013 and LeSean McCoy traded after 2014), so not all of the decline belongs to defenses catching up, but a scheme built on doing a few things fast is also a scheme that opponents get many reps against. The tools they use are the next section. Kelly was let go before the end of the 2015 season.¹⁹

¹⁶"Chip Kelly," Wikipedia (Oregon head coach 2009–2012; Eagles 2013–2015; 49ers 2016): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chip_Kelly.

¹⁷Pro Football Reference, 2013 Philadelphia Eagles (10–6, first in the NFC East; LeSean McCoy led the league in rushing): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/teams/phi/2013.htm>. In this course's nflverse count the Eagles also led all teams in rushing yards that season.

¹⁸Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, regular seasons 2013–2015, runs and passes (scrambles and sacks counted as passes; two-point tries excluded). Offensive rank is by EPA per play among 32 teams. Tempo numbers use the method in the note on the tempo chart.

¹⁹The Eagles released DeSean Jackson on March 28, 2014 (ESPN, "Eagles release DeSean Jackson": https://www.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/10688873), agreed to trade LeSean McCoy to Buffalo for Kiko Alonso in March 2015 (CBS Sports, "We grade the trade": <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/we-grade-the-trade-lesean-mccoy-to-bills-kiko-alonso-to-eagles>), and released Kelly on Dec. 29, 2015, with one game left and the team 6–9 (PhillyVoice: <https://phillyvoice.com/philadelphia-eagles-release-head-coach-chip-kelly>).

How defenses answer tempo

A defense facing tempo has a problem with three parts: it can't change players, it has little time to get a call in, and it has no time to disguise. Its answers go after each part.

Simplify the call. Every defense that expects tempo has a short list of *tempo calls*: one word, or one hand signal, that tells all eleven players the front, the coverage and the rush, with nothing that requires a walk-up, a shift or a disguised rotation. The idea is to be *sound* rather than clever: a call that has an answer for every formation and every run, so that nobody can be caught out of position. The cost is plain in Figure 6: the defense that lines up where it will play gives the quarterback an honest picture, and gives up the disguise and pressure tricks of Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage and Zone Blitzes and Simulated Pressure.

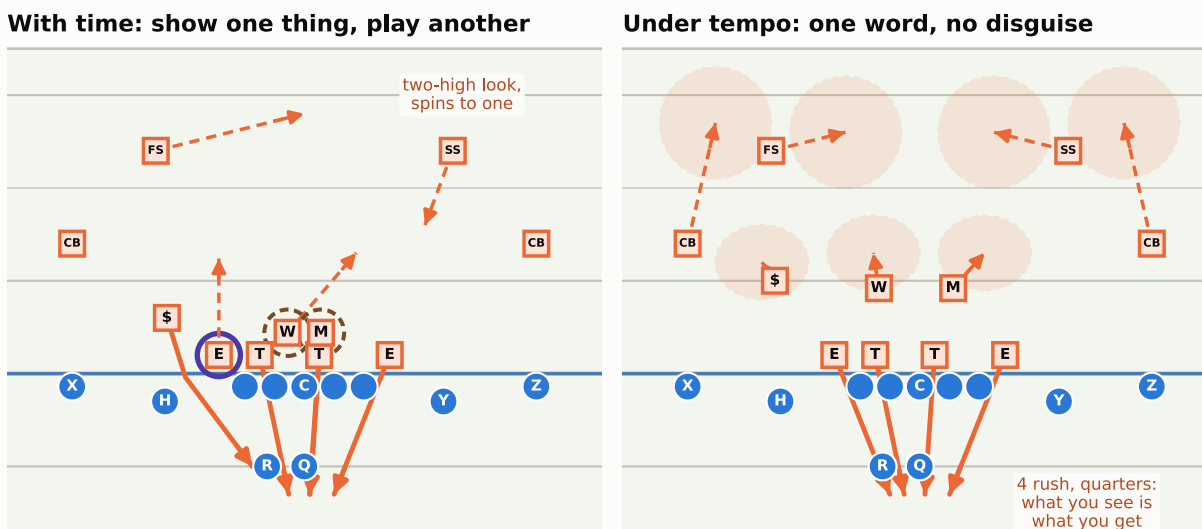


Figure 6: The same defense with time and under tempo (illustrative). Left, with time: a disguised pressure. The defense shows two deep safeties and two linebackers threatening the A gaps (dashed rings), then at the snap the nickel blitzes off the edge, the left end drops into a short zone (purple ring), the free safety spins to the middle and the strong safety comes down: the quarterback's pre-snap read is wrong. All of that needs the call in early and twenty seconds to set the picture. Right, under tempo: a one-word call, four rush and a two-high zone (quarters) behind them, everyone aligned where he will play. It is sound against every formation, and it tells the quarterback the truth.

Let the players adjust by rule. The defensive version of a check-with-me is a call that isn't finished until the offense lines up: the sideline sends a front and a coverage family, and the players finish it themselves according to the formation they see (set the strength to the tight end, play quarters against two receivers on a side and a different rule against three). The green-dot linebacker or the safeties communicate the finishing touches with one or two words. This moves the decision from the coordinator, who is now too slow, to the players, who must be smart and well drilled.

Recruit players who don't need to come off. The deepest answer is roster construction. If your "linebacker" can cover a slot receiver and your nickel back can fit a run like a linebacker, the freeze stops hurting, because your base defense and your nickel defense are the same eleven men. The league-wide rise of hybrid safety-linebackers and the big nickel (a third safety as the fifth defensive back) is partly a response to tempo and spread offenses: it's the defense's way of buying back the substitution the freeze took away.

Slow the game down. And then there are the answers the league polices. The 1988 Seahawks' fake injuries were not the last: in September 2011, after two Giants defenders went down at the same moment against the Rams' no-huddle on *Monday Night Football*, the league sent every team a memo warning of fines, suspensions and even lost draft picks for faking injuries.²⁰ The rules add a cost of their own: before the two-minute warning, a player whose injury stops the game must leave for at least one down,²¹ so a fake costs the defense the faker. Defenses can also take a timeout, the cleanest reset there is, if they're willing to spend it. In college football, where tempo became far more extreme, the rules committee in 2014 proposed a ten-second window at the start

²⁰ Associated Press, "NFL memo warns teams on faking injuries" (Sept. 21, 2011), after Deon Grant and Jacquian Williams went down against the Rams' no-huddle; the memo warned of "fines, suspensions and loss of draft picks": <https://www.washingtontimes.com/news/2011/sep/21/nfl-memo-warns-teams-on-faking-injuries/>. Grant denied faking.

²¹ NFL Rulebook (2026), Rule 4, Section 5, Article 3 (injury timeouts before the two-minute warning: "the injured player must leave the game for the completion of one down," with exceptions): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>.

of each play clock in which the offense couldn't snap, to let defenses substitute. It drew loud opposition from tempo coaches and was shelved.²²

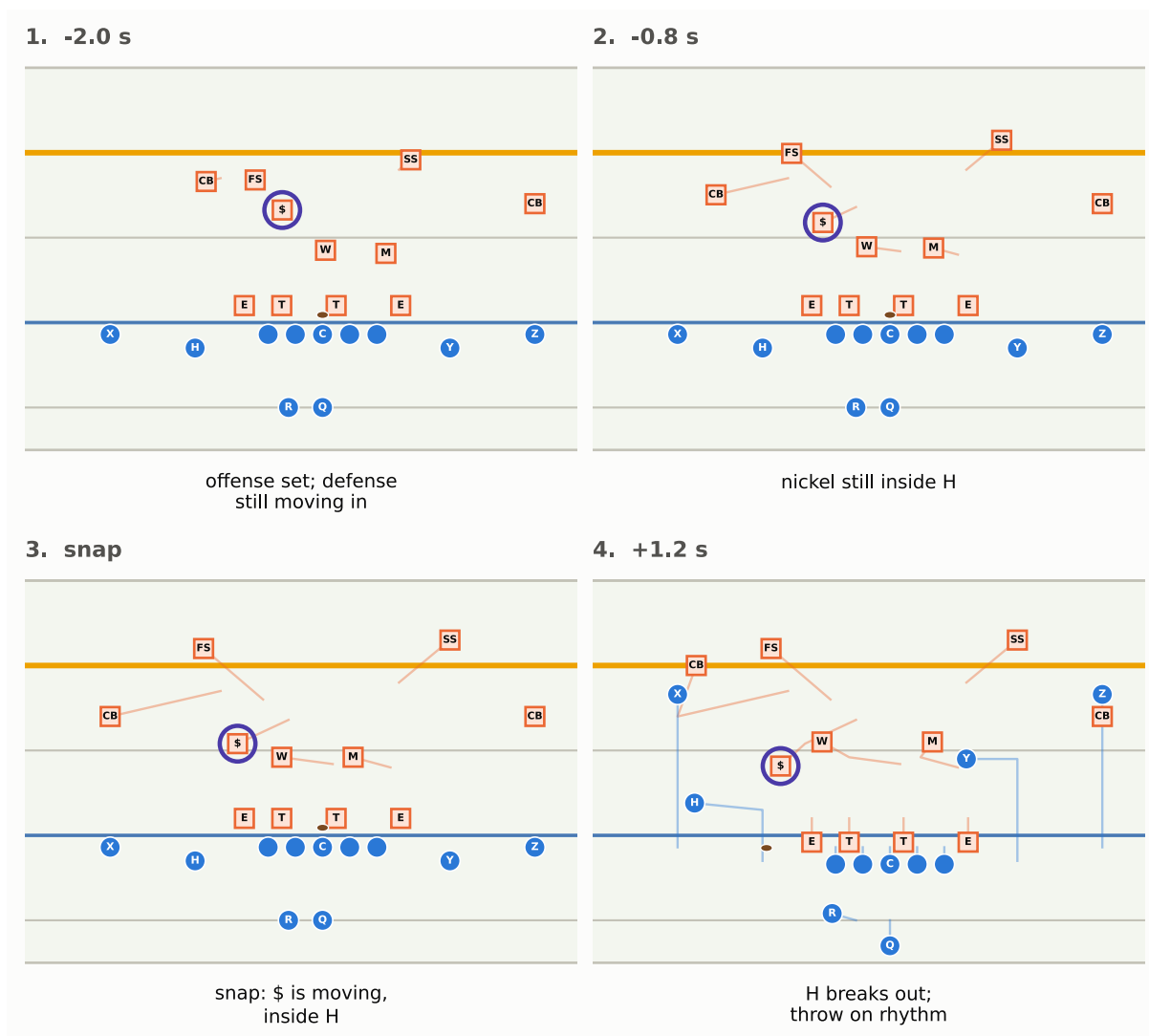


Figure 7: Tempo catching a defense unset (simulated, BDB-format tracking). Panel 1: the offense, which kept its personnel after the last play, is set two seconds before the snap while the defense is still getting the call and moving into place: the cornerback is jogging out to X, the nickel (\$, purple ring) is still inside, walking toward H. Panel 2: a second before the snap, the nickel is still a few yards inside H. Panel 3: the snap comes while he is moving, inside H's shoulder. Panel 4: H breaks to the outside, away from him, and the quarterback throws on rhythm. Nothing about the call was wrong; the defense simply never got lined up.

💡 Watch for it

When an offense goes fast, take your eyes off the ball for one snap and watch the defense's sideline and its secondary. Is anyone running *off* the field as the ball is snapped? Is a defender still pointing or walking to his spot? Is the defense lining up in a plain look it hasn't shown all day? Those are the costs of tempo being paid, and they tell you why the offense chose that moment.

²²*Sports Illustrated*, "NCAA proposes rule change to allow time for defensive substitutions" (Feb. 12, 2014), on the proposal that offenses could not snap until 29 seconds remained on the play clock, outside the last two minutes of each half: <https://www.si.com/college/2014/02/12/ncaa-rule-change-defensive-substitutions-targeting>. The rules committee tabled it on March 5, 2014, before the Playing Rules Oversight Panel could vote on it: Associated Press, "NCAA tables 10-second football rule proposal," *Bangor Daily News* (March 5, 2014): <https://www.bangordailynews.com/2014/03/05/sports/ncaa-tables-10-second-football-rule-proposal/>.

The call after the call

Everything so far has been about each side adjusting to what the other *did*. The best play-callers go one step further and call for what the other side is *about to do*. That is the coordinator-versus-coordinator contest that coaches sometimes call “the call after the call”: you don’t call the play that beats what the defense just ran; you call the play that beats what the defense will run *in response* to what you just did.

Figure 8 is a small, illustrative version over one half. Each box is an answer to the box before it, and each side is trying to stay a move ahead.

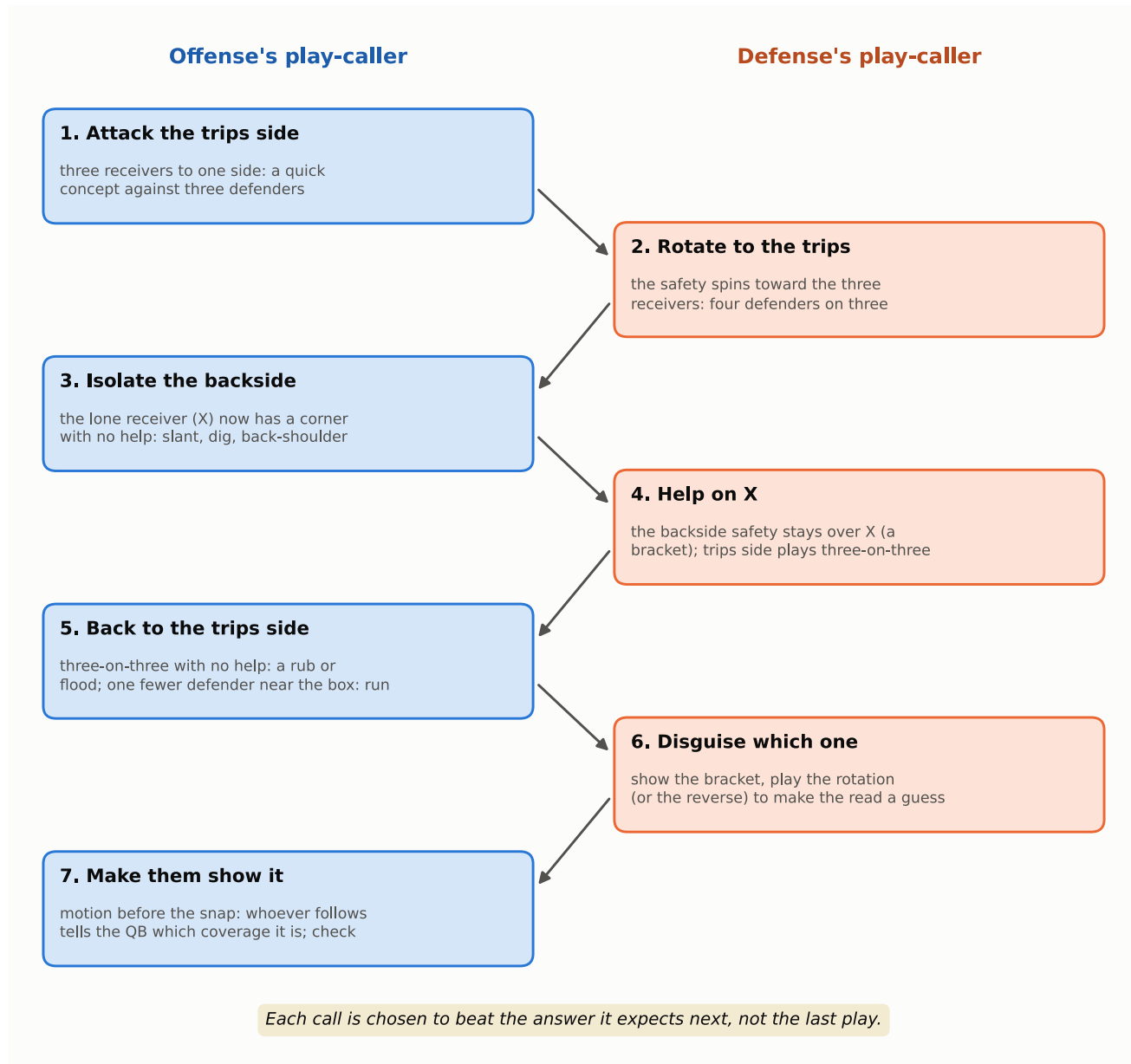


Figure 8: The call after the call (illustrative, one half). Read the boxes in order, zig-zagging between the offense’s play-caller (left) and the defense’s (right). Each call answers the last answer. The offense opens by attacking its three-receiver side; the defense rotates its coverage there; the offense punishes the side the rotation left; the defense helps on that side; the offense goes back to the side that has lost its help; the defense starts disguising which one it’s playing; and the offense uses motion to make the defense show its hand before the snap. Every step is a play from the week’s plan; what changes is the order.

A few things make this contest more than rock-paper-scissors.

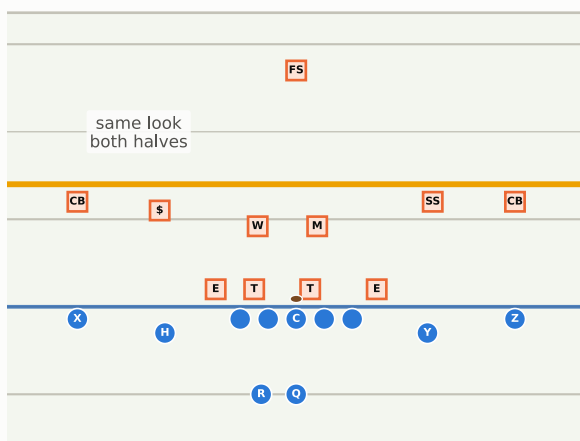
Both sides keep score. The booth’s tallies are not just for the play-caller’s own side. The offensive staff is also tracking the defense’s *answers*: when we showed trips, what did they do; when we motioned, who followed. After a couple of series, each staff has a little in-game tendency report on the other, the live version of the self-scouting and tendency work in Constraint Theory.

The second answer is often the money call. A play-caller can deliberately run a play he expects the defense to adjust to, *in order* to set up the play that beats the adjustment. That's the sequencing idea from Constraint Theory applied across a game, and the reason the most dangerous moment for a defense is often right after it has fixed a problem.

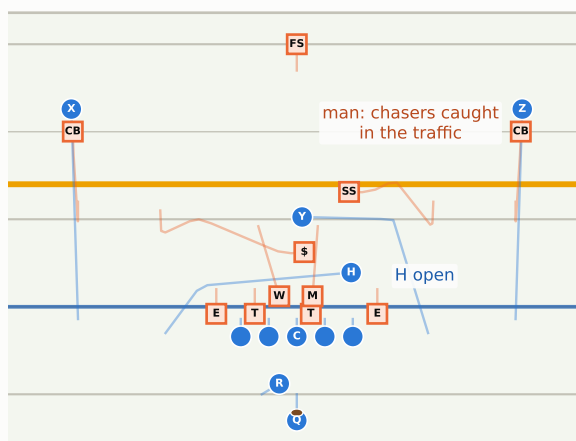
Nobody can go infinitely deep. If the offense calls for the defense's adjustment, the defense can skip the adjustment and stay where it was, and now the offense's clever call is running into the very defense it was designed to avoid. In practice coordinators think about one or two moves ahead, and the deciding factor is usually what the players can execute. A defense with one coverage it plays brilliantly can ignore much of this contest; a defense with five it plays adequately is always one step from a bust.

Here is a single adjustment and its answer as frame pairs. In the first half the defense plays man coverage on third down, and the offense beats it repeatedly with mesh, two shallow crossers that run past each other so the defenders chasing them in man have to fight through traffic. At halftime the defense keeps the same look but changes the rule for the two inside defenders: instead of each chasing one crosser all the way across the field, each sits in his area and takes whichever crosser comes to him, a banjo-style "pass it off" rule (a combo coverage).

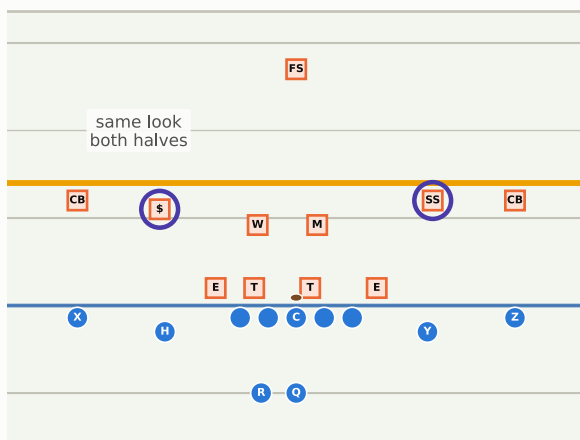
First half: snap



First half: +1.6 s



Second half: snap



Second half: +1.6 s

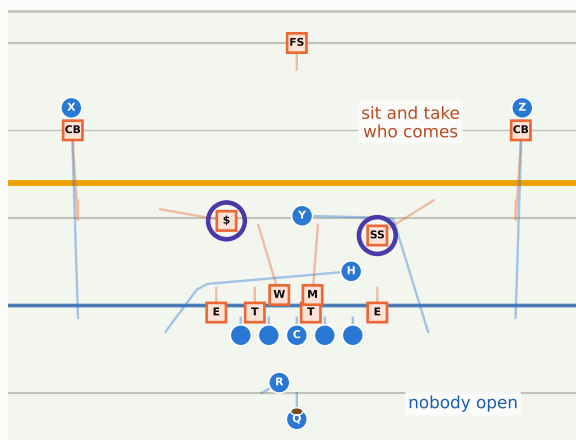


Figure 9: A halftime adjustment as frame pairs (simulated, BDB-format tracking; illustrative). Each row shows the same third-down play at the snap and 1.6 seconds later. Top, first half: the defense plays man coverage behind a six-man rush (both linebackers blitz; the back stays in to block). The two crossers (H from the left, Y from the right) run past each other, the nickel (\$) and strong safety (SS), each chasing his man across the field, are a step behind through the traffic, and H is open as he clears it. Bottom, second half: the same look, the same six rushers and the same play, but the two inside defenders (purple rings) now sit at about five yards and take whichever crosser comes into their area. Each crosser runs straight into a waiting defender, and the quarterback has nowhere to go. The play didn't change; one rule did.

The second-half picture in Figure 9 looks like a win for the defense, and for a series or two it is. But look at what the adjustment gave away. The two inside defenders now *stop* at five yards and wait. A receiver who runs at them and then breaks back the way

he came (a pivot or whip route), or one who keeps going behind them, is running against a defender who is standing still. That is the next call after the call, and you'll get to make it in the drills at the end of the chapter.

i Go deeper: the same pair from real tracking data

With Big Data Bowl tracking data you can build Figure 9 from real plays: find two snaps from the same game, the same offense and a similar look, one from each half, and draw each at the snap and a second and a half later. The code below sketches that with `gridiron.bdb` (it doesn't run in this book, because the tracking files are a separate download from Kaggle). The 2025 edition's files cover weeks 1–9 of the 2022 season, with pre-snap frames included (Tracking Data and the Big Data Bowl).

Do halftime adjustments decide games? Testing the narrative

Back to the analyst's line. If halftime adjustments decide games, three things should show up in the data: second halves should look different from first halves in a way that favors the team with the better staff; a team's first-half performance shouldn't tell you much about its second half (the adjustment breaks the pattern); and some coaches should be consistently better than others at turning a game around after halftime. The play-by-play data lets us check each one. All the numbers below use regular-season games from 2006 to 2025 and leave out the last two minutes of each half and snaps where one team's win probability was above 90%, so that two-minute drills and garbage time don't dominate.²³

First: second halves look exactly like first halves, on average. League-wide, offenses averaged -0.004 EPA per play in first halves and -0.006 in second halves. If defenses (or offenses) systematically out-adjusted the other side at halftime, you'd expect a gap. There isn't one, which is what you'd expect if both sides adjust about equally well, and if most adjusting happens every series rather than once.

Second: the first half tells you very little about the second half, and that's mostly not adjustment. Figure 10 (left) splits about 7,121 team-games by how well each offense played in the first half. Offenses that were terrible before halftime were much better after it, and offenses that were brilliant came back to earth. The correlation between a team's first-half and second-half EPA per play in the same game is only 0.08.

That looks like a story about adjustments, and it's the classic trap of *regression to the mean*. A first half is about 25 to 35 snaps, and EPA per play over that few snaps is mostly noise: a fumble, a dropped pass, a 60-yard run. An offense that had an awful first half was usually an ordinary offense having an unlucky half, and its next half looks ordinary, *whether or not anyone adjusted anything*. The team that "came out a different team after halftime" was often just the same team without the bad bounces. The same arithmetic makes the hot first-half team cool off.

²³Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, regular seasons 2006–2025. Snaps are runs and passes with a down recorded, more than two minutes left in the half and win probability between 10% and 90%. A team-game is kept if the offense had at least 15 such snaps in the first half and 10 in the second. Season-to-season correlations pair each team with itself the next season (608 pairs). The coach chart uses actual scores at the end of the second and fourth quarters (overtime excluded) and each game's listed head coach; coaches with at least 100 games in these seasons are shown. Under pure chance, the standard error of a coach's second-half-minus-first-half margin over a few hundred games is about 0.5–1 point, so differences of up to about 2 points are unremarkable.

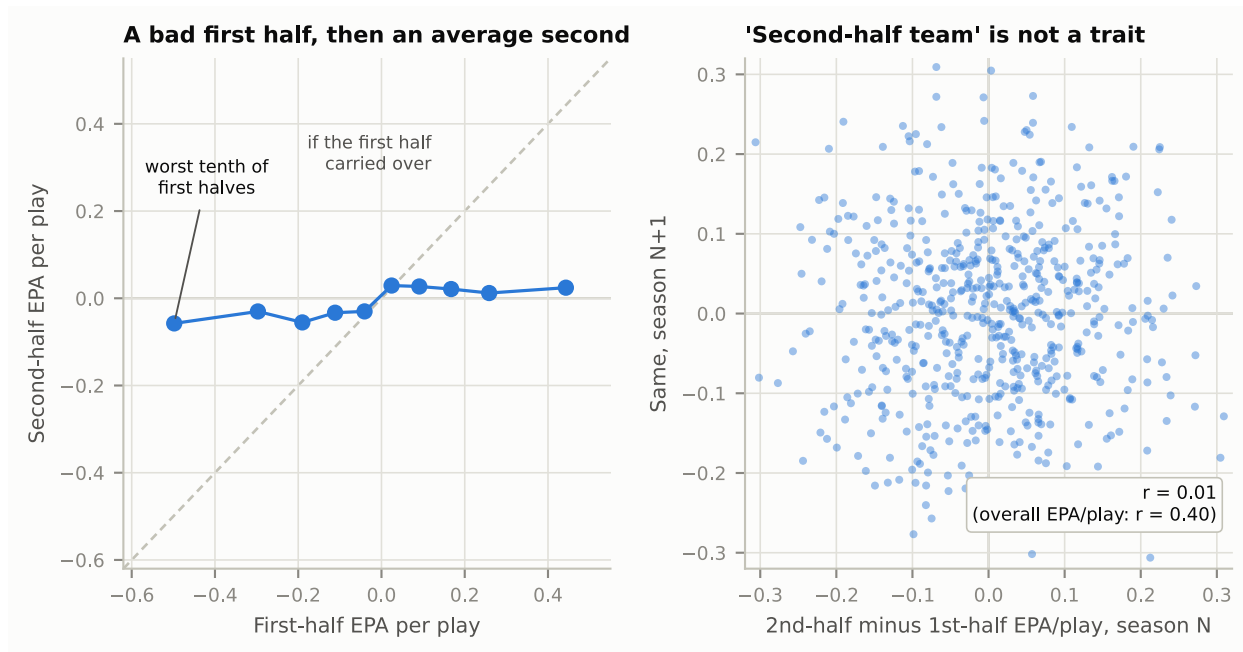


Figure 10: Testing the halftime narrative, 2006–2025 regular seasons (neutral snaps). Left: team-games grouped into tenths by the offense’s first-half EPA per play; each dot is a group’s average first half (x) against its second half (y). If the first half carried over, the dots would lie on the dashed diagonal; instead they lie almost flat: bad first halves were followed by about average second halves, and great ones too. That is regression to the mean, not proof of adjustment. Right: is ‘improving after halftime’ a team trait? Each dot is a team-season’s second-half minus first-half EPA per play, plotted against the same team’s number the next season. There is essentially no relationship (r near zero), while a team’s overall EPA per play carries over from one season to the next quite strongly (r about 0.4). Source: nflverse play-by-play.

Third: no team or coach is reliably a “second-half team.” The right panel of Figure 10 asks whether improving after halftime is a repeatable trait. If some staffs adjusted better than others, a team that improved after halftime in one season should tend to do it again the next. It doesn’t: the year-to-year correlation of a team’s second-half-minus-first-half EPA per play is 0.01 for offenses and 0.05 for defenses, against 0.40 and 0.23 for how good the offense and defense are overall. Being good carries over from one season to the next; being better after halftime doesn’t.

Coaches are the natural place to look next, since a reputation for halftime magic attaches to a person. Figure 11 plots every head coach with at least 100 games in these seasons by his teams’ average scoring margin in first halves and in second halves.

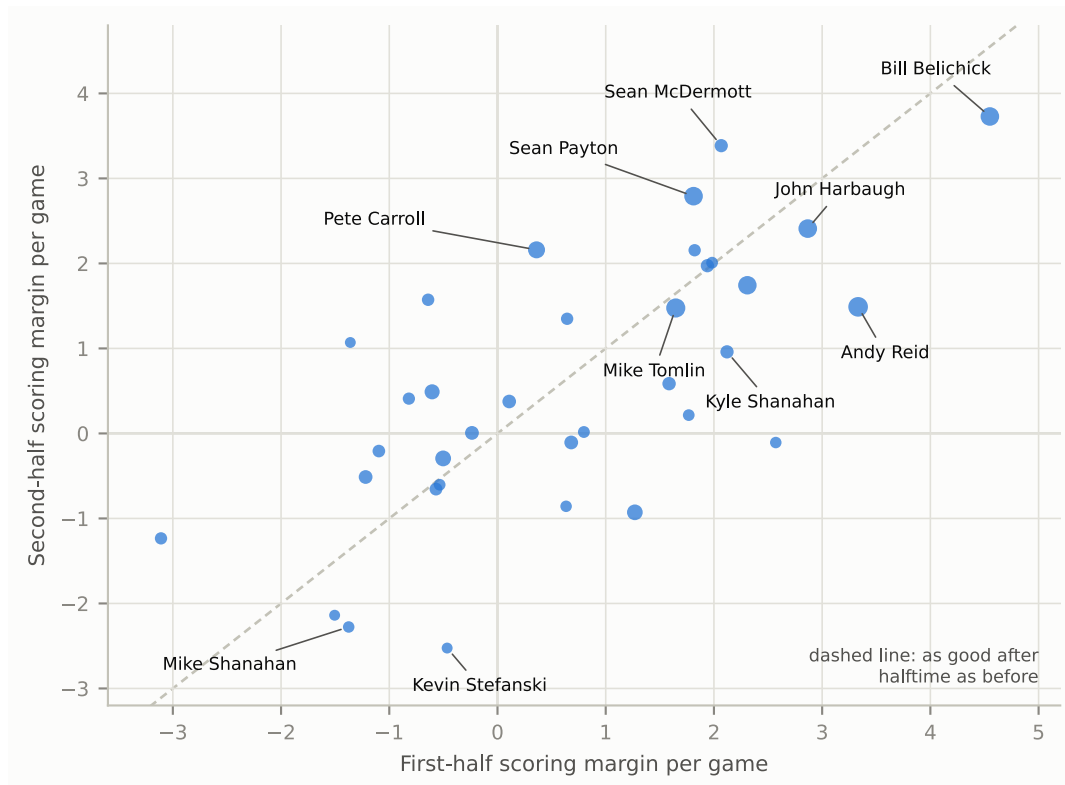


Figure 11: Head coaches with at least 100 regular-season games, 2006–2025: average scoring margin per game in first halves (x) and in second halves, regulation only (y). The dashed diagonal is ‘just as good after halftime as before.’ Good coaches are good in both halves, so the dots rise from left to right. A ‘halftime adjuster’ would sit well above the diagonal; nobody does by more than about two and a half points a game, and nearly every coach’s gap is within two standard errors of zero, about what chance alone produces over 100 to 300 games. The two coaches with the best reputations as game planners, Bill Belichick and Andy Reid, sit *below* it: their teams were better before halftime, and they often led at the half. Source: nflverse play-by-play.

Two forces you can see in Figure 11 explain most of what fans read as halftime magic.

- **Score effects.** Teams that lead at halftime play differently afterwards: they run more, take fewer risks and drain the clock, while teams that trail throw more and gamble. Across these seasons, teams leading by 1 to 13 points at the half were outscored by about 0.3 points in the second half on average, and teams trailing by 1 to 13 outscored their opponents by the mirror amount. That pushes every good team’s second-half margin down and every trailing team’s up, with no locker-room speech required.
- **Possessions.** One team gets the ball first in the second half, and sometimes a long first-half drive means one offense barely played. Second halves can look like turnarounds simply because one offense finally got the ball.

None of this means adjustments are fake. Coaches adjust constantly; the between-series loop is real work that wins plays. The data says something narrower: adjustment is not a *halftime* event that reliably separates staffs, and a big second-half swing is usually explained by noise, score and possessions before you need to credit genius. When a team does turn a game around, look for the specific change.

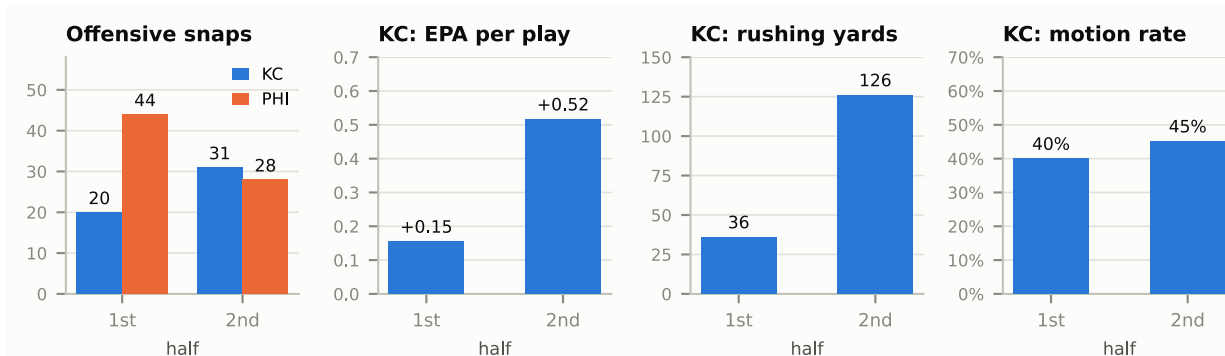


Figure 12: Super Bowl LVII by half (runs and passes only). Kansas City’s offense ran only 20 plays before halftime to Philadelphia’s 44; its EPA per play rose from about +0.15 to about +0.5 (small samples) and its rushing yards from 36 to 126, while its motion rate barely moved. More snaps, a run game and two well-timed calls, not a new motion offense. Sources: nflverse play-by-play; FTN charting (`is_motion`).

i Film room: Kansas City Chiefs, Super Bowl LVII (2022 season)

Super Bowl LVII (February 12, 2023) is everyone’s favorite example of a halftime turnaround. The Eagles led 24–14 at the half; Patrick Mahomes had re-aggravated his injured ankle late in the second quarter; and the Chiefs scored on all four of their second-half possessions to win 38–35, including two fourth-quarter touchdowns on the same motion play (the story of “Corn Dog” is told in *Motion and Shifts* and *What Beats What*).²⁴ “Kansas City’s halftime adjustments” is the usual summary. What does the data say changed?

What to notice: start with the first panel of Figure 12. Kansas City’s offense barely played in the first half: 20 runs and passes against Philadelphia’s 44, because the Eagles’ offense held the ball for long drives. The Chiefs had been effective when they did have it, about +0.15 EPA per play, and the second half gave them 31 snaps. Some of the change was real and visible: the run game went from 36 rushing yards to 126, with Isiah Pacheco and Jerick McKinnon running well and Mahomes scrambling on the bad ankle. What *didn’t* change much was the motion: by FTN’s charting the Chiefs used motion on 40% of first-half snaps and 45% after halftime.²⁵ The two motion touchdowns were a game-plan call used at the right moment near the goal line (the second one set up by Kadarius Toney’s 65-yard punt return, the longest in Super Bowl history), not a new offense invented in the locker room.

So was it halftime adjustments? Partly: the Chiefs ran more and ran better, and the staff saved its best red-zone call for the moments that mattered. But the honest summary also includes more possessions, a punt return and a defense that had played a lot of snaps. That’s the habit this chapter wants you to build: when someone credits halftime, ask what changed, and check how much of it was the clock and the bounces.

²⁴“Super Bowl LVII,” Wikipedia (Kansas City 38, Philadelphia 35, Feb. 12, 2023; 24–14 Philadelphia at halftime): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LVII; *Sports Illustrated*, “Patrick Mahomes Reinjures Ankle in Second Quarter of Super Bowl LVII” (Feb. 13, 2023): <https://www.si.com/nfl/2023/02/13/patrick-mahomes-reinjures-ankle-second-quarter-super-bowl-lvii>; Chiefs.com, “Kadarius Toney Comes Through in a Big Way as Part of Record-Setting Super Bowl” (65-yard punt return, the longest in Super Bowl history): <https://www.chiefs.com/news/kadarius-toney-comes-through-in-a-big-way-as-part-of-record-setting-super-bowl>. Snap counts, EPA and rushing yards by half are a course calculation from nflverse play-by-play.

²⁵FTN charting via nflverse (`load_ftn_charting`), whose `is_motion` flag means motion occurred on the play before *or at* the snap: https://nflreadr.nflverse.com/articles/dictionary_ftn_charting.html. It is not comparable with PFF’s shift-and-motion series.

💡 Watch for it on Sunday: the adjustment hunter

Pick one team for a game and keep a short list in two columns, first half and second half.

Before the snap

- **Personnel:** which groups does the offense use, and does the defense still match them? A team that lived in 11 personnel and comes out in 12 has changed its plan.
- **Tempo:** does the offense go fast after big plays? Does the defense look rushed, with players running off at the snap or a plain, undisguised look?
- **Motion:** more or less of it after halftime, and does the defense still follow it the same way?
- **Coverage shell:** two-high or one-high before the snap, and does it change after the half?

After the snap

- **Pressure:** count rushers on third down in each half. Did a blitz that worked disappear, or one that got burned stop coming?
- **Protection:** is a back or tight end staying in to help a struggling tackle after halftime?
- **The fix and the answer:** when the defense changes something, watch the next series. Does the offense call the play that beats the change? That's the call after the call.

Then check the box score: who had more snaps in each half, and who led at halftime? Before you credit an adjustment, ask whether the scoreboard and the clock explain the second half.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: the same eleven, in a hurry

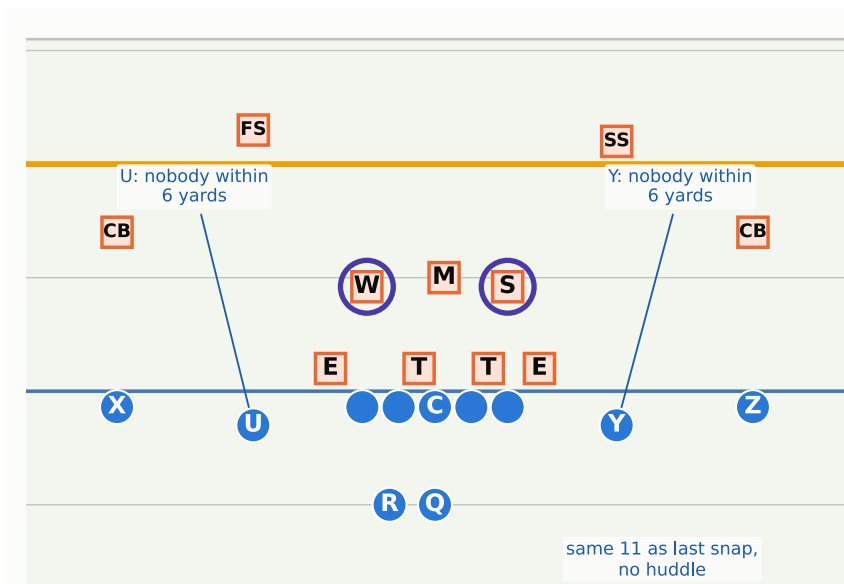


Figure 13: First-and-10, second quarter. On the previous snap the offense, in 12 personnel with both tight ends attached, gained 19 yards on a play-action pass; the defense was in base personnel. Eight seconds after the tackle the offense is set again with the same eleven players, both tight ends flexed into the slots. The defensive coordinator waved for his nickel back, then waved him off. The defense's outside linebackers have stayed close to the box (purple rings) and the safeties are deep.

What will the offense do, and when will it snap?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: the call after the call

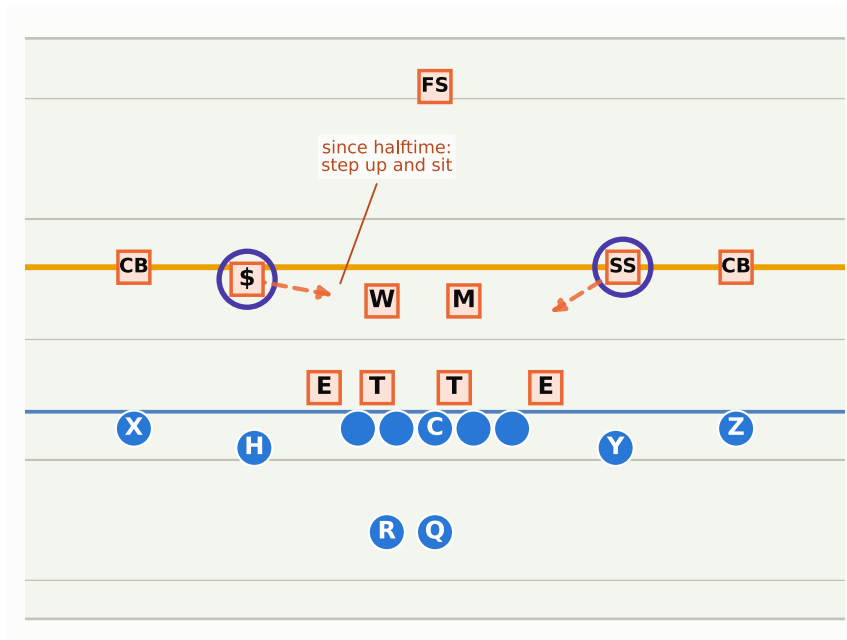


Figure 14: Third-and-6, third quarter. Same offense, same 2x2 formation as in the first half, when mesh (two shallow crossers) beat the defense's man coverage three times. Since halftime the defense has shown the same single-high look, but its two inside defenders (purple rings) now sit at five yards and pass the crossers off to each other, and it has stopped three straight crossing plays. The faint dashed arrows show what those two defenders did on those plays: they stepped up and sat.

The offense has seen the adjustment. What does it call now, and who is it aimed at?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: the quick huddle on fourth down

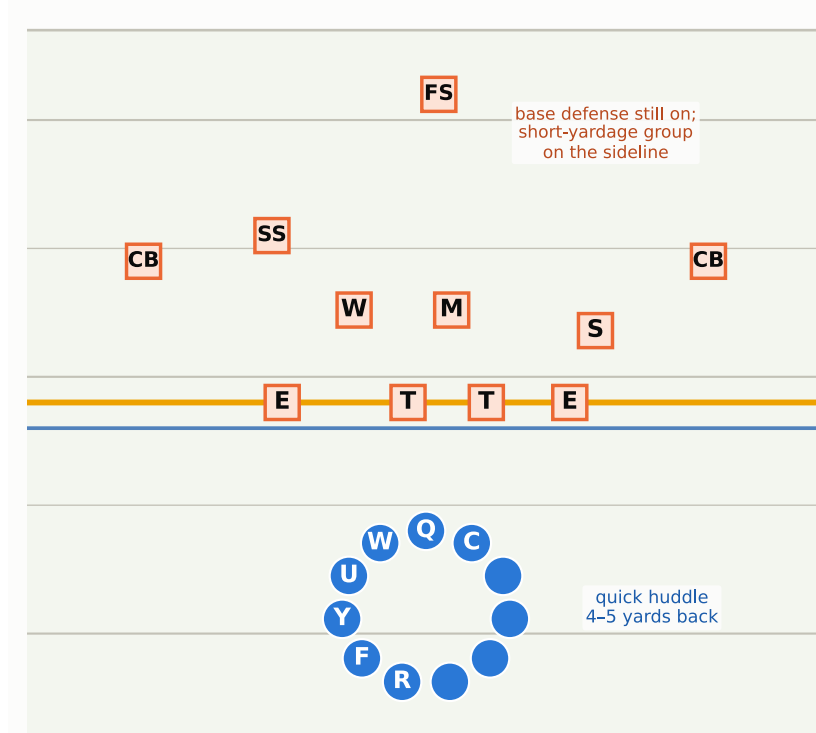


Figure 15: Fourth-and-1 near midfield, early in the fourth quarter. On third down the offense was stopped a yard short. Instead of waiting, it has gathered in a tight huddle about five yards behind the ball, already with three tight ends and a fullback on the field, while the defense still has its base personnel out there and its heavier short-yardage group waiting on the sideline.

The play clock shows 35.

Why huddle so close, and what's likely to happen in the next ten seconds?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- **Adjusting is constant and small.** Between series, the booth's tallies and the tablet photos meet the coaches and players on the bench, and what comes out is a rule, an alignment, a protection call or a re-ranked call sheet, chosen from plays already practiced.
- **Tempo is a weapon about the rules, not just speed.** The defense may match personnel only when the offense substitutes, so an offense that keeps its eleven and goes fast freezes the defense in the wrong players, tires it, and strips away its disguise. The sugar huddle gets the same benefits with a huddle's clarity.
- **Tempo costs the offense too.** One personnel group, simple calls, tired players and, above all, its own defense back on the field after a fast three-and-out. Kelly's Eagles were the fastest offense in the league for three seasons and their defense faced the most plays each year.
- **Defenses answer tempo by being sound rather than clever:** one-word calls, rules the players finish themselves, and versatile players who never need to come off. The league polices the rest.
- **The call after the call** is choosing the play that beats the defense's *next* answer. Watch the series after a team fixes something.
- **"Halftime adjustments" mostly don't survive the data as a decisive, repeatable skill.** First and second halves look the same league-wide, bad halves regress to the mean, being better after halftime doesn't carry over from season to season, and score effects and possessions explain most big swings. Ask what changed.

Connections

Builds on: The Game Plan (the menu every adjustment chooses from), What a Play Really Is (the staff, the booth, the no-huddle and the 15-second cut-off), Personnel Groupings (substitution matching), The Pre-Snap Phase (checks and check-with-me), Constraint

Theory (sequencing and tendencies, here played out within a game), and Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage (what tempo takes away from a defense).

Sets up: The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down (tempo when time is short, and the timeout decisions that halftime and the end of a game force); The Belichick Patriots (Super Bowl XXV's answer to the K-Gun); Tendencies: PROE, Personnel, Motion, and Coverage (charting a game the way the booth does); and Watching Live, which turns this chapter's adjustment hunter into a full live-game checklist.

[i Go deeper](#)

Geoff Hobson's Bengals.com history of the 1988 season (in the notes) tells the no-huddle showdown from Wyche's side. The NFL rulebook's Rule 5, Section 2 is short and worth reading in full: it is the whole legal basis of the substitution game, and Football Zebras (footballzebras.com) explains each season's changes to it in plain language. Chris B. Brown's *The Art of Smart Football* (2015) is a readable collection of essays on how offensive ideas, tempo among them, move from college football to the NFL. For the analytics, regression to the mean is the single most useful idea to carry into any sports argument; this chapter's code is a template for testing any "second-half team" claim, and Win Probability and Decision Analysis covers the score effects behind Figure 11.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

Snap fast and throw quickly to a tight end, most likely Y or U on a quick hitch, out or seam, before the linebackers can widen. This is the substitution freeze working exactly as designed. The defense is stuck in base personnel, and its outside linebackers have chosen to stay near the box, where they're useful against the run. That leaves both flexed tight ends with soft or no coverage underneath: the nearest defenders are a linebacker several yards inside and a safety eleven yards deep. A tempo offense's quarterback is usually taught a simple count rule for this: if they won't cover him, throw it to him.

If instead the linebackers had walked out over the tight ends (as in Figure 4), the count flips: five defenders in the box against five linemen, and the offense would run the ball, or throw at the linebacker covering a tight end in space. Either way the offense wants the snap *now*, before the defense can get a call in or call a timeout. The defense's best realistic answer, if it sees this coming, is a timeout to get its nickel on the field, which costs it a timeout in the first half: exactly the trade tempo is designed to force.

Answer 2.

A route that uses the sitting defenders' new habit against them: most likely a pivot (whip) route by a slot receiver, or a crosser that keeps climbing behind them, with the target being the space the sitter just committed to leave. The second-half rule tells each inside defender to stop at about five yards and take whoever comes into his area. A slot receiver who runs straight at that defender as if he's crossing, then plants and snaps back the way he came, is working against a man who has just committed to the cross; the defender is standing still and has to turn and chase. Many offenses pair it with a crosser from the other side that, instead of flattening at five yards, keeps climbing to eight or ten, behind the sitters and in front of the deep safety.

This is the call after the call: the offense isn't trying to beat the first-half man coverage any more, and it isn't simply running mesh again. It's punishing the specific way the defense fixed mesh. Expect the defense to answer that, too, perhaps by mixing the man coverage back in so the sitters can't be read in advance. If you said "run the ball," that's reasonable partial credit: two defenders standing at five yards looking for crossers are a step slower to the run, but on third-and-6 most play-callers would rather attack the adjustment directly.

Answer 3.

It's a sugar huddle, and the offense wants to snap before the defense can get its short-yardage personnel on the field, set its own call, or call a timeout: expect a fast snap and a short-yardage run, most likely a quarterback sneak or an inside run behind the extra tight ends. The huddle lets the offense give a precise call to everyone at once (no signals for the defense to steal) and still get to the line almost immediately. Because the offense already has its heavy personnel on the field from third down and isn't substituting now, the umpire won't stand over the ball for the defense: if the defense starts sending in its goal-line players, it risks being caught with twelve on the field.

The defense's realistic choices are to play the down with what it has, using a simple short-yardage call, or to spend a timeout, which buys it a substitution and a call but costs it a timeout in the fourth quarter and gives the offense time to think about a

different play. Some offenses also use the threat itself: a quick huddle that makes the defense burn a timeout has already won something.